THE SPREAD AI -- NFL Week 5, 2026

Picks against the Vegas spread only. Model = ridge + neural-net ensemble + gradient boosting on opponent-adjusted play-by-play ratings, QB, rest and context, trained to predict how far the result lands from the line.

BACKTEST (walk-forward, 2018-2026, 2191 games never seen in training): all picks 51.5% ATS (95% CI 49.4-53.6%), break-even 52.4%. NO tier is VALIDATED out-of-sample (needs 54%+ on 100+ games and p<0.10 vs break-even): treat every pick as an UNPROVEN lean, not a bankable edge.

TIER	GAME	DATE	VEGAS	MODEL	PICK	EDGE	COVER	PROJ SCORE	ATS THIS SEASON	WHY (biggest drivers)
C 51.2% on 252	**PHI @ JAX**	10-11	JAX -7.0 nflverse schedule	JAX -7.8	**JAX -7.0**	0.8	52%	PHI 17, JAX 25	JAX 3-1 (home 2-0) PHI 0-4 (road 0-2)	recent record vs the number (favors away); success-rate edge (favors home); turnover-tendency edge (favors home)
C 51.2% on 252	**MIN @ NO**	10-11	NO +1.5 nflverse schedule	NO +0.7	**NO +1.5**	0.8	52%	MIN 22, NO 21	NO 2-2 (home 0-2) MIN 3-1 (road 2-0)	success-rate edge (favors home); scoring-margin edge (favors away); away pass offense vs home pass D (favors away)
C 51.2% on 252	**DET @ ARI**	10-11	ARI +5.5 nflverse schedule	ARI +6.1	**DET -5.5**	0.6	52%	DET 30, ARI 24	ARI 2-2 (home 0-1) DET 0-3-1 (road 0-2)	success-rate edge (favors away); home pass offense vs away pass D (favors away); early-down efficiency edge (favors home)
PASS	**NYG @ WAS**	10-11	WAS -3.5 nflverse schedule	WAS -3.0	NO PLAY	0.5	52%	NYG 20, WAS 23	WAS 2-2 (home 1-1) NYG 3-1 (road 0-1)	
PASS	**DEN @ LAC**	10-11	LAC +3.5 nflverse schedule	LAC +3.1	NO PLAY	0.4	51%	DEN 22, LAC 19	LAC 0-3-1 (home 0-2) DEN 2-2 (road 0-2)	
PASS	**CHI @ GB**	10-11	GB +2.5 nflverse schedule	GB +2.1	NO PLAY	0.4	51%	CHI 24, GB 22	GB 0-3-1 (home 0-1) CHI 3-1 (road 1-0)	
PASS	**CIN @ MIA**	10-11	MIA +6.5 nflverse schedule	MIA +6.9	NO PLAY	0.4	51%	CIN 25, MIA 18	MIA 1-3 (home 0-1) CIN 2-2 (road 1-1)	
PASS	**BUF @ LA**	10-12	LA -3.0 nflverse schedule	LA -2.6	NO PLAY	0.4	51%	BUF 26, LA 29	LA 2-2 (home 1-1) BUF 3-1 (road 1-0)	
PASS	**IND @ PIT**	10-11	PIT -2.5 nflverse schedule	PIT -2.8	NO PLAY	0.3	51%	IND 21, PIT 24	PIT 2-2 (home 2-0) IND 3-1 (road 2-0)	
PASS	**BAL @ ATL**	10-11	ATL -3.5 nflverse schedule	ATL -3.2	NO PLAY	0.3	51%	BAL 20, ATL 23	ATL 2-2 (home 0-1) BAL 1-2-1 (road 1-0-1)	
PASS	**CLE @ NYJ**	10-11	NYJ -1.5 nflverse schedule	NYJ -1.8	NO PLAY	0.3	51%	CLE 19, NYJ 21	NYJ 2-1-1 (home 1-0) CLE 3-1 (road 1-1)	
PASS	**LV @ NE**	10-11	NE -3.5 nflverse schedule	NE -3.8	NO PLAY	0.3	51%	LV 21, NE 25	NE 2-1-1 (home 1-0) LV 4-0 (road 2-0)	
PASS	**SF @ SEA**	10-11	SEA -2.5 nflverse schedule	SEA -2.3	NO PLAY	0.2	51%	SF 22, SEA 24	SEA 1-1-2 (home 0-0-2) SF 3-1 (road 1-0)	
PASS	**HOU @ TEN**	10-11	TEN +7.5 nflverse schedule	TEN +7.4	NO PLAY	0.1	50%	HOU 22, TEN 15	TEN 2-2 (home 1-1) HOU 0-4 (road 0-1)	
PASS	**TB @ DAL**	10-08	DAL -8.5 nflverse schedule	DAL -8.5	NO PLAY	0.0	50%	TB 19, DAL 28	DAL 2-1-1 (home 1-0-1) TB 0-3-1 (road 0-1)	

*TIER = how large the model's disagreement with Vegas is (A = top 5% of out-of-sample disagreements, B = top 15%, C = top 30%; below that = NO PLAY). * = that tier is VALIDATED out-of-sample (54%+ on 100+ games, p<0.10 vs break-even); the small print under a tier is its real backtest ATS record. EDGE = shrunk points of value vs the line. COVER % = estimated chance the pick covers (a normal-curve estimate; ignores key-number effects at 3 and 7). MODEL = the program's fair line, PROJ SCORE splits the market total. ATS THIS SEASON = each team's record against the spread (W-L-push), overall and at this game's venue. Betting 1 unit flat at -110 needs 52.4% to break even.*

HOW IT HAS REALLY DONE

	Out-of-sample ATS record
All picks	51.5% (1099-1035-57, n=2134) 95% CI 49.4-53.6% ROI -1.7%
ridge alone	50.9% (1087-1047-57, n=2134) 95% CI 48.8-53.1% ROI -2.8%
mlp alone	50.0% (1067-1067-57, n=2134) 95% CI 47.9-52.1% ROI -4.5%
gbm alone	51.6% (1101-1033-57, n=2134) 95% CI 49.5-53.7% ROI -1.5%
blend alone	51.5% (1099-1035-57, n=2134) 95% CI 49.4-53.6% ROI -1.7%
Tier A	52.9% (37-33-2, n=70) 95% CI 41.3-64.1% ROI +0.9%
Tier B	56.6% (86-66-5, n=152) 95% CI 48.6-64.2% ROI +8.0%
Tier C	51.2% (129-123-6, n=252) 95% CI 45.0-57.3% ROI -2.3%
Season 2018	50.2% (124-123-9, n=247) 95% CI 44.0-56.4% ROI -4.2%
Season 2019	55.7% (137-109-10, n=246) 95% CI 49.4-61.8% ROI +6.3%
Season 2020	55.1% (141-115, n=256) 95% CI 49.0-61.1% ROI +5.1%
Season 2021	52.2% (140-128-4, n=268) 95% CI 46.3-58.1% ROI -0.3%
Season 2022	46.0% (120-141-10, n=261) 95% CI 40.0-52.0% ROI -12.2%
Season 2023	47.7% (123-135-14, n=258) 95% CI 41.7-53.8% ROI -9.0%
Season 2024	52.6% (141-127-4, n=268) 95% CI 46.6-58.5% ROI +0.4%
Season 2025	52.4% (142-129-1, n=271) 95% CI 46.5-58.3% ROI +0.0%
Season 2026	52.5% (31-28-5, n=59) 95% CI 40.0-64.7% ROI +0.3%

Correlation of the model with (real margin - line): +0.048. Shrink slope earned out-of-sample: 0.55 (1.00 would mean the raw model is perfectly calibrated; NFL models usually earn well under 0.5). Average miss: line alone 9.84 pts, line + shrunk model 9.84 pts.

LIVE RECORD (every pick this program has logged since you started running it)

No graded picks yet -- they grade themselves the next time you run it after the games are final.

Data: nflverse (CC BY 4.0). Live lines: The Odds API consensus (median of US books) unless a manual file is present. This is analysis, not a guarantee. Past out-of-sample results do not promise future ones.